

of the whole 136, reveals the following datum, both astonishing and significant: only two proper variants could be said to make any difference in the meaning—4 and 122! But before looking at them more closely, I should mention that 1700 shares a variant with $\aleph$ seventeen times, with P⁶⁶ and W each fifteen times, with A nine times, with B and D each eight times; but as I have already argued, we can scarcely claim a dependency—the errors were simply made independently (with the exception of the few places where there is massive agreement).

Now I will analyze items 4 and 122. Was the place where John was baptizing Bithabara or Bethany? Whichever name we choose, we do not know the exact location, except that it was on the eastern side of the Jordan River. (Those maps that place it on the western side mislead their readers.) From the very beginning, who in Asia Minor or Europe would know the exact location, whatever its name? It follows that the choice of name makes no difference to the point of the narrative; the important thing is what happened, not where it happened.

Did Pilate say, “We have a custom” or “You have a custom” (122)? The MSS attestation in favor of ‘you’ is 80%. But really now, how could the Jews have a custom that placed an obligation on their conquerors? It is scarcely credible that imperial Rome would release a prisoner based on a Jewish demand, so the reading of Family 35 is doubtless correct. However that may be, the choice of pronoun makes little difference to the point of the narrative, which is that the Jews chose Barabbas rather than Jesus.

Although as representatives of Family 35 go GA 1700 is rather pitiful, for all that, someone reading 1700 for devotional purposes would not be misled as to the intended meaning at any point! I submit that this conclusion is highly significant. In spite of its 136 deviations, 1700 is an adequate copy of John’s Gospel for all practical purposes. So what about all those nasty ‘accumulated errors’ alleged in the RSV preface? I recognize the possibility that 1700 may have up to 57 inherited errors, errors taken from an exemplar, but since they would make little or no difference to a translation into English, they do not agree with RSV’s purpose in mentioning ‘accumulated errors’.

Going back to the RSV preface, I now invite attention to the final sentence: “We now possess many more ancient manuscripts of the New Testament, and are far better equipped to seek to recover the original wording of the Greek text.” The use of the verb ‘recover’ indicates that they considered the original wording to have been lost. The linking of “far better equipped” to “more ancient manuscripts” indicates that they considered the older to be better. In fact, the committee that produced the RSV